

BARRIERS AND SOLUTIONS

GOALS OF THE EXERCISE

1. Understand the relationship between the stress of occupational problems and addiction.
2. Identify connections between occupational problems and addictive behaviors.
3. Identify behavioral changes that would help resolve occupational problems.
4. Identify thoughts and feelings associated with current and past work problems.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE OCCUPATIONAL PROBLEMS

- Balancing Recovery, Family, and Work
- Communication Skills
- Consequences of Continuing Addictive Lifestyles
- Identifying Conflict Themes
- Interest and Skill Self-Assessment
- Negotiating Skills for Success
- Understanding My Defense Mechanisms
- What Price Am I Willing to Pay?
- What's Addiction Got to Do with My Problems?

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Borderline Traits
- Legal Difficulties

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Barriers and Solutions” activity is suited for the client who has consistently experienced problems at work. For clients unable to see the relationships between their addictive behaviors and work problems, this exercise will help increase insight. For the client who can recognize a relationship between addiction and work problems, but needs assistance identifying relapse risk factors, it will help increase awareness and help with solutions. The activity helps clients identify feelings, thoughts, and behavioral responses that may be barriers to successful employment, and it helps them generate possible solutions. Achieving awareness and taking personal responsibility for behavior are two critical aspects of recovery. Addressing occupational problems and their relationship to addictive behavior

and lifestyle will require dealing with the denial, minimization, or blame associated with these difficulties. For clients who are not currently employed, it can be used to assess past difficulties so that future employment is geared toward success.

BARRIERS AND SOLUTIONS

Occupational problems take many forms: problems with authority, conflict with coworkers, stressful work environments, addictive behavior being supported or encouraged, adjustment to retirement or lay-off, underemployment or unemployment due to poor performance or attendance problems, and so on. Cause-and-effect connections between addictions and problems at work run both ways. Addictive behavior may cause work problems (e.g., poor performance, absences, reduced ability to concentrate, more accidents), and the work environment may contribute to addiction and relapse. This exercise will help you to identify relationships between difficulties you've had with work and with addictive behavior, and to create solutions.

1. Please list the last four jobs you've held and the problems you've had in each job.

2. List the common problems you have had in work environments in the left-hand column. In the right-hand column, identify the connections to addictive behaviors or ways these problems are recovery issues. We've given you some examples.

Problem*Fired for insubordination**Lack of meaning to life after retirement***Relationship to Addiction/Recovery***Conflicts with authority figures**Used addictive patterns to cope*

3. If you are currently working, how does your work environment place you at risk of relapse (e.g., coworker's addictions; job dissatisfaction; long work hours)?

4. What is your plan to address each of the risks you identified in question 3?

5. What are your feelings and concerns about the workplace situations you listed for question 3?

6. What discouraging thoughts or self-talk have you had, or do you have now, about your work situation (e.g., "I won't be able to do this job," "I'll fail like the other times," "No one will hire me")?

7. For each negative thought you identified in question 6, write a more realistic, positive replacement thought (e.g., "I'm as capable as the other people doing this job, if they can do it so can I," "I've learned from past mistakes and am better prepared").

8. What behavior changes do you need to make to solve or avoid problems you've had at work in the past? It may help to ask others you trust to make suggestions here.

9. What will you do this week to address one of the problems you listed for question 3?

10. What will you do during the next month to address this problem?

-
11. After completing questions 9 and 10 and carrying out the actions you said you would take, record your evaluation of how you did.

Remember to bring this handout with you to your future therapy sessions and talk over any questions or ideas you have, and be prepared to talk about this assignment with your therapist or your group.